

Misplaced and Dangling Modifiers

Misplaced Modifiers

A misplaced modifier is a word, phrase, or clause that is improperly separated from the word it modifies / describes.

Because of the separation, sentences with this error often sound awkward, ridiculous, or confusing. Furthermore, they can be downright illogical.

Example

On her way home, Jan found a **gold man's** watch.
↑
misplaced modifier

The example above suggests that a **gold man** owns a watch.

Misplaced modifiers can usually be **corrected** by **moving** the modifier to a more sensible place in the sentence, generally next to the word it modifies.

Example

On her way home, Jan found a man's **gold watch**.
↑
correctly placed modifier

Now it is the **watch** that is **gold**.

There are several kinds of misplaced modifiers:

1. Misplaced adjectives are incorrectly separated from the nouns they modify and almost always distort the intended meaning.

Example 1

The child ate a **cold dish** of cereal for breakfast this morning.

↑
misplaced adjective (modifies *dish*)

Correct the error by placing the adjective *next to the noun it modifies*.

Corrected

The child ate a dish of **cold cereal** for breakfast this morning.

↑
correctly placed adjective (modifies *cereal*)

Example 2

The **torn student's** book lay on the desk.

↑
misplaced adjective (modifies *student*)

Corrected

The student's **torn book** lay on the desk

↑
correctly placed adjective (modifies *book*)

Sentences like these are common in everyday speech and ordinarily cause their listeners no trouble. However, they are quite imprecise and, therefore, **should have NO place in your writing.**

2. Placement of adverbs can also change meaning in sentences.

For example, the sentences below illustrate how the placement of ***just*** can change the sentence's meaning.

Just means **only John** was picked, **no one else**:

Just John was picked to host the program.

Just means that John was picked **now**:

John was **just** picked to host the program.

Just means that John hosted **only the program, nothing else**:

John was picked to host **just** the program.

Each of these sentences says something logical but quite **different**, and its correctness depends upon what the writer has in mind.

Often, **misplacing an adverb** not only alters the intended meaning, but also creates a sentence whose meaning is highly unlikely or completely ridiculous.

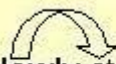
This sentence, for example, suggests that we *brought* a lunch *slowly*:

We ate the lunch that we had brought **slowly**.



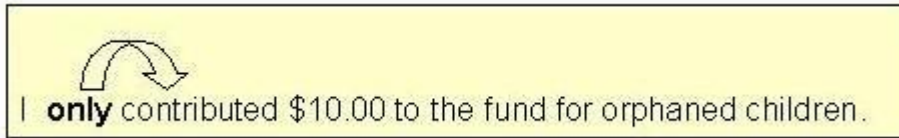
To repair the meaning, move the adverb *slowly* so that it is near *ate*.

We **slowly** ate the lunch that we had brought.

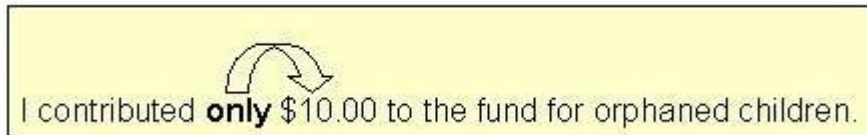


Watch out for adverbs such as ***only, just, nearly, merely,*** and ***almost.*** They are often misplaced and cause an unintended meaning.

This sentence, for example, means that I only **contributed** the money:



Repaired, however, the sentence means that I contributed only **\$10.00**.



Like adjectives, adverbs are commonly misplaced in everyday speech, and may not cause listeners difficulty. However, such sentences are quite imprecise and, therefore, **should have NO place in your writing.**

Now click on the link below to complete Exercise 1.

[Link to Exercise 1](#)

3. Misplaced phrases may cause a sentence to sound awkward and may create a meaning that does not make sense.

The problem sentences below contain misplaced phrases that modify the wrong nouns.

To fix the errors and clarify the meaning, put the phrases ***next to*** the noun they are supposed to modify.

Example 1 (a buyer with leather seats?)

The dealer sold the Cadillac to the  **buyer with leather seats**.

Corrected

The dealer sold the  **Cadillac with leather seats** to the buyer.

Example 2 (a corner smoking pipes?)

The three bankers talked quietly in the  **corner smoking pipes**.

Corrected

The three  **bankers smoking pipes** talked quietly in the corner.

Example 3 (a house made of barbed wire?)

They saw a fence behind the  **house made of barbed wire**.

Corrected


They saw a **fence made of barbed wire** behind the house.

Click on the link below to complete Exercise 2.

[Link to Exercise 2](#)

4. Misplaced clauses may cause a sentence to sound awkward and may create a meaning that does not make sense.

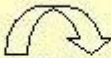
The problem sentences below contain misplaced clauses that modify the wrong nouns.

To fix the errors and clarify the meaning, put the clauses **next to** the noun they are supposed to modify.

Example 1 (a buttered woman?)


The waiter served a dinner roll to the **woman that was well buttered**.

Corrected


The waiter served a **dinner roll that was well buttered** to the woman.

Example 2 (a hamper that Ralph wore?)

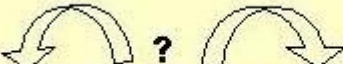

Ralph piled all of his clothes in the **hamper that he had worn**.

Corrected


Ralph piled all of his **clothes that he had worn** in the hamper.

Be careful! In correcting a misplaced modifier, don't create a sentence with two possible meanings.

Example

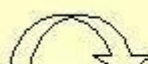
 ?
The teacher said **on Monday** she would return our essays.

Problem: Did the teacher **say** this on Monday or will she **return** the essays on Monday?)

Correction #1 (meaning the essays will be returned on Monday)


The teacher said she would return our essays **on Monday**.

Correction #2 (meaning that the teacher spoke on Monday)


On Monday the teacher said she would return our essays.

Click on the link below to complete Exercise 3.

[Link to Exercise 3](#)

DANGLING MODIFIERS

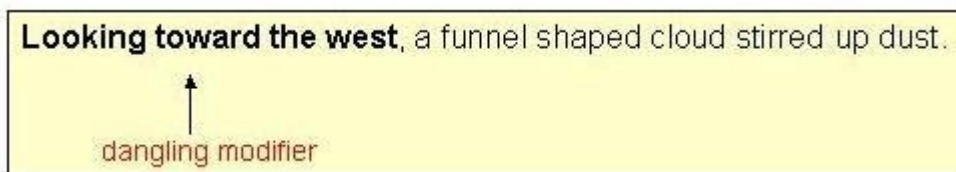
A **dangling modifier** is a phrase or clause that is not clearly and logically related to the word or words it modifies (i.e. is placed next to).

Two notes about dangling modifiers:

- Unlike a misplaced modifier, a dangling modifier cannot be corrected by simply moving it to a different place in a sentence.
- In most cases, the dangling modifier appears at the beginning of the sentence, although it can also come at the end.

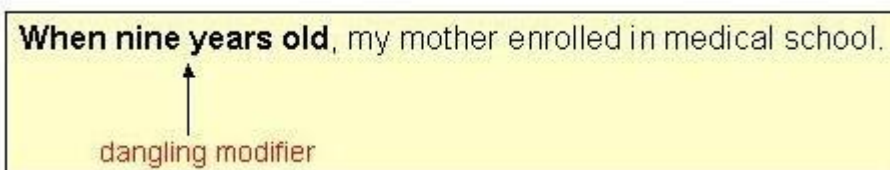
Sometimes the dangling modifier error occurs because the sentence fails to specify anything to which the modifier can refer.

Example 1



This sentence does not specify **who** is **looking toward the west**. In fact, there is nothing at all in the sentence to which the modifying phrase **looking toward the west** can logically refer. Since the modifier, **looking toward the west**, is sitting next to **the funnel shaped cloud**, the sentence suggests that the **cloud** is doing the looking.

Example 2



This sentence means that my mother enrolled in medical when she was nine years old!

At other times the dangling modifier is placed next to the wrong noun or noun substitute.

Example 1

Walking to the movies, the cloudburst drenched Jim.

↑
dangling modifier

Because of the placement of **walking to the movies**, this sentence suggests that the **cloudburst** is **walking to the movies** even though a possible walker - **Jim** - is mentioned later.

Example 2

Having been fixed the night before, Priscilla could use the car.

↑
dangling modifier

Since **having been fixed the night before** is placed next to **Priscilla**, the sentence means that **Priscilla was fixed the night before**.

As the above examples show, dangling modifiers result in **inaccurate** and sometimes **ludicrous** statements.

How to correct dangling modifiers

Dangling modifiers may be corrected in two general ways.

Correction Method #1

1. Leave the modifier as it is.
2. Change the main part of the sentence so that it **begins** with the term **actually modified**.
3. This change will put the modifier **next to** the term it modifies.

Thus, this dangling modifier

Looking toward the west, a funnel shaped cloud stirred up dust.

↑
dangling modifier

may be corrected to


Looking toward the west, **I** saw a funnel shaped cloud stir up dust.

Now the sentence means that **I was looking toward the west**.

Using the same method, this dangling modifier

Walking to the movies, the cloudburst drenched Jim.

↑
dangling modifier

may be corrected to


Walking to the movies, **Jim** was drenched by the cloudburst.

Now the sentence means that **Jim was drenched by the cloudburst**.

Click on the link below to complete Exercise 4.

[Link to Exercise 4](#)

Correction Method #2

1. Change the dangling modifier phrase to a subordinate clause, creating a subject and verb.
2. Leave the rest of the sentence as it is.

Thus, the dangling modifier

When nine years old, my mother enrolled in medical school.

↑
dangling modifier

may be corrected to

When I was nine years old, my mother enrolled in medical school.

↑ ↑
subject verb

Now the sentence means that **I** (not my mother!) was nine years old when my mother enrolled in medical school.

Using the same method, the dangling modifier

Having been fixed the night before, Priscilla could use the car.

↑
dangling modifier

may be corrected to

Since the car had been fixed the night before, Priscilla could use it.

↑ ↑
subject verb

Now the sentence means that the **car** (not Priscilla!) was fixed.

Click on the link below to complete the final exercise.